

NEWS ANALYSIS

A Tit for Tat Piles On Pain With No End

Civilian Toll Climbing
in Ukraine and Russia

This article is by Kim Barker, Oleksandra Mykolyszyn and Ivan Nepochurenko.

KYIV, Ukraine — They are both igniting warehouses filled with food or online-shopping orders near major cities. They are blasting ports and ships carrying vital exports of grain. And they are smashing energy networks that keep the lights on and vehicles fueled.

Russia and Ukraine, in cities far from the front line, are waging an intensifying tit-for-tat air war that is bringing more pain to the populations of both countries than at any other point since the early months of the full-scale war launched by Moscow in 2022.

With the front largely frozen, each side is using growing arsenals of missiles and drones to exact vengeance and to try to pummel the other into submission. In the latest example, Kyiv, the Ukrainian capital, has been under constant bombardment from Russian drones over the past few days, with residents tormented by nearly constant air-raid alerts.

Still, there is no evidence that the escalation will weaken either country’s determination to fight on. Human suffering will only grow this winter, analysts say, as both Russia and Ukraine seek leverage in U.S.-backed settlement negotiations that are expected to resume after achieving little this year.

Ukraine can’t give up, and Russia doesn’t want to, analysts say.

“It’s a question of how much pain can Russia take compared to Ukraine — and Russia can take a lot of pain,” said Rob Lee, a military expert at the Philadelphia-based Foreign Policy Research Institute who travels

Continued on Page A6



KELSEY MCCLELLAN FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Bloom Defies Gloom and Doom

Dahlias, the official flower of San Francisco, have gained new popularity as an antidote to the modern world. Pages A18-19.

NATIONAL A11-19, 24

Firefighter Targets Discontent

One Democrat thinks he can harness Montanans’ anger over out-of-state wealth driving up costs, something his party has long failed to do. PAGE A11

Trillionaire Opens War Chest

Elon Musk plans to spend at least \$100 million to help Republicans in more than a dozen competitive House and Senate races this year. PAGE A14

ICE Agent Accused of Lying

The charges marked a rare instance of President Trump’s Justice Department accusing a federal agent of breaking the law while on the job. PAGE A24

INTERNATIONAL A4-10

A Wedding, Then Carnage

A bomb that struck Iran was American, according to a weapons expert and a visual analysis by The Times. PAGE A8

Heat Changes Italian Attitudes

Amid record-breaking temperatures, more homes and businesses are installing air-conditioning units. PAGE A4



GLORIA STEINEM, 1934-2026



ROBERT WALKER/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Gloria Steinem at the 1975 U.N. Women’s Solidarity Rally. She overcame a fear of public speaking to lecture around the globe.

Her Voice, Pen and Vigor Lifted Countless Women

By KATHARINE Q. SEELYE

Gloria Steinem, the feminist crusader who galvanized the modern women’s movement, helping millions of women develop a sense of self-worth and gain a measure of equality at home, at work and in society at large, died on Wednesday at her home in Manhattan. She was 92.

Her death was announced in a post on social media, which did not give a cause.

Calling herself “an entrepreneur of social change,” Ms. Steinem helped usher in sweeping cultural transformations across virtually every facet of American life, from the boardroom to the courtroom to the bedroom.

For more than half a century, she personified the women’s movement and became its most enduring symbol; her tinted aviator glasses and curtain of streaked-blond hair parted in the center made her one of the most recognizable women in the world.

She was an unlikely revolutionary. Growing up a transient in the Midwest, she was 10 when her parents divorced and she was left to mother her mentally anguished mother — a formative experience that reverberated throughout her life. She had scant formal education until sixth grade; her big dream, as a budding tap dancer, was to become a Rockette.

But she read voraciously, graduated from college with honors and believed

fiercely that women should be able to live whatever life they chose.

Her own feminist awakening didn’t come until her mid-30s, when, as a journalist in 1969, she attended a “speak out” of women discussing their illegal abortions. Charismatic, articulate, media savvy, deeply empathetic and a workaholic, she evolved into a political and cultural force.

She led protests and consciousness-raising sessions, wrote essays and delivered speeches, delved into political organizing, helped establish rape crisis centers and shelters for battered women, founded numerous groups that promoted women and had the Midas touch when it came to

Continued on Page A20

Using Civil Rights Post as a Tool Against the Left

By GLENN THRUSH
and MICHAEL C. BENDER

WASHINGTON — Harmeet Dhillon offered a four-word summation of her four-decade campaign to tear down the ramparts of liberal academia during a private gathering last September.

“I’m going after Harvard,” said Ms. Dhillon, the head of the Justice Department’s civil rights division, according to audio of the event in New Haven, Conn., obtained by The New York Times.

Ms. Dhillon, 57, has repurposed a unit created to address Jim Crow injustices into a battering ram against the elite left. In part, it represents the culmination of a mission she began as an undergraduate at Dartmouth College: to impose conservative change on liberal institutions she still views as the entrenched establishment.

Ms. Dhillon, a gladiatorial Republican lawyer from California who has emerged as a Washington power player, has gone after

Getting Big Institutions to Knuckle Under

more than 100 schools, extracting agreements, cash and personnel moves from big institutions over their diversity and antisemitism policies. In one instance, her pressure prompted the president of



KYLIE COOPER/REUTERS

Harmeet Dhillon

one high-profile school, the University of Virginia, to take early retirement.

“Harvard wished they never heard her name,” President Trump said about Ms. Dhillon last year.

Harvard is apparently not alone. Ms. Dhillon has antagonized enemies and colleagues alike with a confrontational approach and a habit of beefing with co-workers that might hurt her chances of moving higher in the department, current and former department officials said.

Yet the issue that could most define Ms. Dhillon’s tenure looms just over the horizon: the division’s role in monitoring the administration of the midterm elections, as Republicans face the prospect of losing the House and perhaps the Senate and Mr. Trump reprises his falsehoods about election fraud to undermine unfavorable results.

Ms. Dhillon’s much-publicized

Continued on Page A16

‘Lightning Speed’ of the White House Is Outrunning the Courts

By ADAM LIPTAK

WASHINGTON — The courts cannot keep up with President Trump.

In cases on immigration, spending, mass firings and restructuring agencies, the administration has barreled ahead in the face of slow-moving legal challenges. If Mr. Trump loses when those lawsuits are finally resolved, it may

be too late as a practical matter to undo what he has achieved.

The challenge to Mr. Trump’s enormous White House ballroom project is just the latest example of a mismatch between a judicial system characterized by unhurried deliberation and a presidency built for speed.

“Trump is going to get his ballroom — even if courts conclude it’s illegal,” said Leah Litman, a

As Judges Deliberate, a Ballroom Gets Built

law professor at the University of Michigan.

Over the past few months, three judges and four justices concluded that Mr. Trump likely violated a federal law by razing the

East Wing and replacing it with a luxury building.

Five other justices did not dispute that conclusion, ruling instead that the challengers probably lacked a direct interest in the matter sufficient to give them standing to sue.

The litigation continues — but so does the construction. Mr. Trump said Tuesday that the

Continued on Page A15

SPORTS B6-10

Harsh Penalties for Clippers

The N.B.A. hammered the team for circumventing the salary cap to compensate Kawhi Leonard, stripping it of five first-round picks and suspending the owner Steve Ballmer. PAGE B9

Phillies Star Is Locked In

Bryce Harper is again showing that when he is focused — truly focused — there is almost nothing he cannot will himself to do on a baseball field, and his team is profiting because of it. PAGE B6

OPINION A22-23

Jill Filipovic

PAGE A22



WEEKEND ARTS C1-8

Tales of the City, Firsthand

A cast of 100 — mostly amateurs, ages 7 to 84 — tell their own stories as New Yorkers in “Public Record,” for five nights at the Delacorte Theater. PAGE C1



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